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SPECIALE SANREMO / MALIKA AYANE

I WHO NEVER WEAR ARMOR

Text by ALESSIA ERCOLINI

THE SINGER **MALIKA AYANE** HAS ALWAYS WANTED TO EXPERIMENT. AT A CERTAIN POINT, HOWEVER, SHE REALIZED SHE ALSO NEEDED TO PROTECT HER OWN SENSIBILITY. SO SHE MOVED TO BERLIN, EXPERIENCED ANONYMITY, AND FOUND A NEW BALANCE. AND NOW THAT SHE HAS RETURNED TO THE FESTIVAL, SHE HAS DONE SO TO TALK ABOUT THE LOVE THAT GIVES JOY AND STABILITY.

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The first time I met Malika Ayane was at her debut on the Ariston stage in 2009. Her song back then, *Come foglie*, was a success and, over time, her unique voice—defined by singer-songwriter Paolo Conte as "the color of a dark orange that tastes of bitter and rare spices"—became familiar. Today Malika Ayane, 42, lives between Berlin and Milan, and finally, the time has come for her sixth appearance at the Sanremo Festival, where she sings the track *Animali notturni*. On the set of the *Grazia* photo shoot, the singer moves lightheartedly and amused, even though she confesses that posing in front of the lens doesn't make her feel entirely at ease. "It's something I haven't learned how to do yet," she says. "I love fashion, I like the idea that a photograph can invent a world and build a story. Yet every time, my expressions seem to suggest something very serious is happening: they never match those millions of nuances I'm made of. But wearing these wonderful clothes was beautiful."

MALIKA, WHAT IS IT LIKE RETURNING TO SANREMO? "It risks being a very fun thing. The first time on that stage was in 2009 and Arisa was also in the competition. The last time was five years ago and it was the Covid edition, with the theater completely empty. It was a very intense experience in which I realized that being a singer has a value and it's important to transmit emotions to others. Since then, I have certainly grown both from an artistic point of view and in terms of self-control, but at the same time, I am lucky enough to continue doing the things I like. In these years, I haven't deprived myself of any possibility to experiment inside and outside of music: I've done theater, radio, and everything with great curiosity. Returning to Sanremo with a lot of road under my shoes and a great desire to have fun is wonderful."

YOUR TRACK ANIMALI NOTTURNI IS A LOVE SONG. "Yes, and when I heard it for the first time, I told myself it was perfect for me. For once, I wanted to tell a light story. Choosing someone and living them, despite the multitude of people and the infinite possibilities of encounters, is a blessing. I found it relevant to who I am, and not just regarding romantic stories, but also relationships with friends. When you live with limited time, you choose who to share it with and you realize that having the luck to be able to choose is something extraordinary to pay attention to. In songs, we always tell when a love begins or when it ends, but we don't glorify it enough when we are lucky enough to have it. Normality, at times, is an exceptional goal."

IF YOU HAD TO SUMMARIZE YOUR TURNING POINTS OF THE LAST 20 YEARS? "A lot of fun things happened. Sometimes in life, similar or parallel situations reappear, stories I've already lived or that make me think of something I've already seen, and at that point, I have to decide: can I face them in the same way or with slightly different nuances? Sometimes. Perhaps there is a cyclicity in life as there is in fashion. For example, 12 years ago I took a house in Berlin and I took it exactly on the street where I wanted it. I had started thinking about my album *Naïf* and considering doing things in a..."

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"...different way, like moving away from the center of the scene, cultivating my own anonymity, my own authenticity. I believe the turning point was a very long journey that lasted these ten years in which I learned to give space, but also to protect my sensitivity. There are people who are born with less skin than others, and therefore cannot live differently. I am one of those, but I never wanted to wear armor, so I either came out exhausted or I learned to keep my skin safe. In Berlin, I found the right distance and I don't know if it's yoga or motherhood, but these are the things that have triggered small turning points in my life every day. Or at most every three."

YOU BECAME A MOTHER AT ONLY 21, GOING AGAINST THE TREND COMPARED TO YOUR PEERS. "I was unconsciously very wise. And in my experience, motherhood saved me. If already in youth and with success we all fall sometimes into the illusion of being special, the fact of having to take care of another human being who banally depends on you for their survival makes you less self-centered and can be a blessing. Mia is now 20 years old and is at an age where I see the result of her education. I am very relaxed, I don't have wrinkles, Mia turned out well, she is a good person, very normal, who does very normal things. With children, however, you also have to be lucky; there are also wonderful people who have fool children, poor things, and vice versa. When you have the luck of being able to see a

grown daughter who lives her life and makes her discoveries, who doesn't give you worries, you can afford to live more freely even with work, something I had never tried before. A tour of 56 dates like the one I just closed in theater, with the show *Brokeback Mountain, A Play with Music*, would never have been possible with a younger Mia."

WHAT KIND OF MOTHER HAVE YOU BEEN FOR HER? "We have a beautiful relationship: I am the mother, she is the daughter (*she laughs, ed.*). I have always tried to treat her not as an extension of me, but as a person since she was microscopic. Then we always get it wrong, as Caterina Caselli (artist and the first record producer to launch her, *ed.*) used to tell me: 'The one who makes the fewest mistakes wins'."

AND IN LOVE, WHAT HAVE YOU UNDERSTOOD? "I know that the people you love and have loved in life have been part of your story and of what you have become. And in the end, being able to love is always a gigantic fortune. There are people who don't have it and maybe spend a long time with someone, but they never discover it."

ARE YOU LIVING A LOVE AT THIS MOMENT IN YOUR LIFE? "I'll just say that I am very happy. I don't like revealing details of my private life; if I did another job, I wouldn't even have social media. I would only post the music I listen to or the restaurants where I ate. I never shared much about my daughter either before she was grown; no one knows what face she has. Because I am the one who chose this life, I am the public figure, not those who love me, not my family. When a personal choice involves others, you must always take other people into account. My mother, for example, makes me laugh a lot when they ask her about me. Once, standing in line at a supermarket checkout, a lady said: 'I saw your daughter on TV'. Another stranger added: 'Why, what does her daughter do?'. And my mother: 'The public'."

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MODA

A FREE WOMAN

Text by **ANTONELLA BIGOTTO**

To give substance to the image of the Spring-Summer 2026 collection, Luisa Spagnoli chose photographer Giampaolo Sgura. «I wanted to tell the story of a free, conscious woman, deeply connected with herself and the world around her,» Nicoletta Spagnoli, president, CEO, and creative director of the brand, told *Grazia*.

«A natural femininity that needs no artifice but finds strength in the balance between elegance and authenticity. She is a woman who lives her body in harmony, chooses garments that accompany her movement without constraining it, and sees fashion as a tool to express her identity with grace and confidence. She is a vital, independent, and refined woman who does not chase nature because she is part of it.»

And the collection speaks precisely of this: of lightness, of harmony, of natural materials, often impalpable. The volumes are in continuous transformation, with sartorial details. The palette is inspired by nature, photographed on a sunny day. The collection is made of statement pieces, but also of garments to be worn daily. «I tried to define an attitude more than a trend,» continues the creative director. «But if I had to choose one item, I would say the Saharan jacket, because it perfectly synthesizes the spirit of the season: it is structured but natural, feminine but decisive, capable of defining the silhouette without rigidity. It is a versatile piece that expresses the balance between tailoring and lightness and tells the idea of vital elegance that guides the entire collection.»

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MODA

THE RIGHT CHORD

CREATIVITY AND HARMONY ARE THE COMMON THREAD GUIDING THE DIEGO M COLLECTIONS

Text by ANTONELLA BIGOTTO

For Diego Mazzi, president and creative director of Diego M, working with leather is a return to his roots and means building a bridge between tradition and the future. In the Spring-Summer 2026 collection, he dedicates space to this material—precious and natural, perfect for all seasons.

Where do you start when interpreting leather? «From the observation of what surrounds me, the trends, the requests of customers. Then I conduct research on materials. Diego M signature leather must be light and meet the strictest sustainability requirements.»

Then there is your touch. «Yes, of course, I like to say that my garments are *made in Diego*. In the end, it is my creativity that mixes all the inspirations to make the collections coherent and recognizable. At this moment, I particularly like raw-cut edges that give softness and lightness to the garment. Generally, all cuts are becoming more fitted and clean.»

And the details? «I like there to always be something unexpected in the garments: a hood with a retractable visor, a drawstring that changes the look of the piece, a pleat that opens and makes the sleeve more elegant.»

What is the representative garment for Spring 2026? «I choose the trench coat, rich in ample volumes and a martingale that holds them with elegance, in a showerproof glazed canvas that is structured yet very comfortable. In leather, the cuts are treated with sartorial precision—impeccable and wearable.»

How would you describe your creative process? «I like to think of it like music, which is a fundamental element of my life, a background that always accompanies me. Inspiration, colors, fabrics, and details are like the elements of an orchestra that together create harmony.»